

Council Meeting  
January 24, 2017  
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The Claremont City Council held a joint meeting with the School Board on Tuesday, January 24, 2017, in the John Goodrich Room of the Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center, 111 South Street.

The meeting was called to order by School Board Chair Brian Rapp at 6:00 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Carolyn Towle  
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope  
At-Large Councilor Keith Raymond  
Assistant Mayor Victor Bergeron  
Mayor Charlene Lovett  
At-Large Councilor Allen Damren  
At-Large Councilor Bruce Temple  
Ward III Councilor Nicholas Koloski

Absent:

At-Large Councilor John Simonds

Members of the School Board present were:

Brian Rapp, Chair  
Chris Irish, Vice Chair  
Patrick Adrian (late)  
Alexander Herzog  
Michele Pierce (late)  
Frank Sprague

Absent:

Brent Ferland

Also present:

Dr. Middleton McGoodwin, School Superintendent  
Representative John Cloutier  
Representative John O'Connor  
Representative Francis Gauthier

## **CITIZEN'S FORUM**

No one spoke.

## **NEW BUSINESS**

### Education Stabilization Update and Discussion

Mayor Lovett said she sent a letter to the House Education Committee requesting support for HB 525, Stabilization Grants for Education. She said she and Dr. McGoodwin testified in Concord and they think they got the support of the Education Committee.

At 6:05 p.m. Michele Pierce arrived.

Dr. McGoodwin said Claremont has had a loss of almost \$400,000 this year and by 2020, the loss will be almost \$1 million. He said he appreciates the State Representatives' support.

At 6:07 p.m. Patrick Adrian arrived.

Mayor Lovett read the letter she submitted to the House Education Committee requesting support for HB 525, Stabilization Grants for Education.

Mayor Lovett thanked the Reps for their support. She said this will go to the House Finance Committee and it will be more important to testify there. She talked about the money coming from the lottery for education. She said it brings in about \$75 million in revenue, but that's only a portion of the \$1 billion needed for education.

Rep. Cloutier said that he supports the bill. He also said that he co-sponsored HB 597 regarding calculating the cost of an opportunity for an adequate education and providing fiscal capacity disparity aid.

Rep. O'Connor said he supports both bills.

There was a discussion about having more lead time for notifications. Rep. Cloutier said the legislative calendar comes out on Thursday and he can try to keep an eye out for items that pertain to Claremont. Normally, they don't have a lot of notice. Rep. Gauthier offered to share the calendar when it comes out. Dr. McGoodwin said when he gets information from the Superintendents Association, he will send it to the Council as well as the School Board, and Mayor Lovett said when she gets information from NHMA, she will send it to the School Board.

There was discussion about whether or not Governor Sununu supported the stabilization bill.

Mr. Rapp said the Governor has vocalized support for the state paying for full-day kindergarten which would also be helpful. He asked if Rep. Gauthier could speak with the Governor to see where he stands on the stabilization bill. Mr. Gauthier said he will do that if he has the opportunity to meet with the Governor.

Rep. Cloutier said that support for funding will depend on how it will affect one's own community. This is an issue where party doesn't matter. It is good to build alliances in the House and Senate. He hopes the Governor will sign it, but first it has to go through the House, Education Committee, Finance Committee and then to the Senate. He said it is important to communicate with Senator Martha Hennessey and to invite her to Claremont. He said the Governor is not very familiar with Claremont, so he invited the Governor to come to Claremont to learn about its successes and challenges.

Rep. Gauthier said he has a town by town spreadsheet of gains and losses and it was requested that he share it with both these governing bodies.

Mr. Temple talked about the Governor of Vermont asking all Vermont school boards to freeze budgets due to declining enrollments and costs that have outstripped property owners' ability to pay the bill. He said there is a common thread about the ability to pay for education.

Bernie Folta, Ward 3, suggested the City and School District could share a communication person and one of the jobs of that person could be to follow and communicate to Councilors and School Board members regarding legislative tracking specific to Claremont.

Mayor Lovett said Senator Hennessey will be invited to future joint meetings of the Council and School Board and will work on getting the Governor invited as well. Mayor Lovett said that she, Mr. Rapp, Dr. McGoodwin and the new City Manager will work with the Delegation to make that happen.

#### Lead Screening/Prevention Update and Discussion

Mayor Lovett said since the last joint meeting, a lunch & learn was held at Valley Regional Hospital. Pediatricians were informed about the importance of screening 100% of the 0-6 year olds for lead poisoning and as a result, the number of screenings has skyrocketed. In the last 12 months the hospital screened 137 and 47 of them were screened in December and January. The lunch & learn helped meet the criteria for a federal block grant to be able to receive a lead testing machine valued at \$2,500. She suggested the School Board set a policy to require lead screening of all children before entering kindergarten.

Mr. Rapp said that is one of the things they are looking at.

Dr. McGoodwin said the budget process is coming to an end soon and then they will turn their attention to this policy as it is a top priority.

Mayor Lovett said she spoke to Gail Gettens, Health Promotion Advisor and Child Development Specialist, Healthy Homes and Lead Poisoning Prevention Program, regarding legislative updates for lead screening and preventing lead poisoning. It will go before Health and Human Services. Mayor Lovett talked about getting community support before this becomes law. She said Ms. Gettens is trying to get a movie here regarding lead poisoning which may need a

sponsor to help pay for it to come here. Mayor Lovett suggested playing at it the Opera House for Claremont and surrounding communities.

Mayor Lovett said there is a commission at the state level studying this topic. She thinks a lot of concerns will be addressed when the bill is released. She asked the Reps to let everyone know when they need to testify.

Mayor Lovett said the action items for this are that the School Board will work on a policy for the beginning of the next school year. An education campaign will be launched using various tools such as the movie presentation. The Representatives will track the number once the bill is released. She asked if there was a consensus to put together a committee to organize the education campaign.

Dr. McGoodwin said the School District is on board with that. Mr. Rapp agreed. Mayor Lovett asked for those from the School Board that are interested to contact Dr. McGoodwin and the Council to contact her. She said she would reach out to Peter Wright, Valley Regional Hospital, to utilize the county assets to do this. She said she would get someone from the Sullivan County Public Health Network on the committee.

#### School/City Budget Discussion

Mayor Lovett commended the School Board for its work to keep the taxrate from increasing.

Mr. Rapp said they worked hard to find the money without affecting education and staffing. After this meeting the School Board will go over reductions the staff worked on.

Mayor Lovett said the City Council is just beginning its budget cycle. The Council's focus will be to level-fund the budget or perhaps have a 5% reduction. She said the health insurance went up 23.1%. She said both governing bodies need to work together on this. Developing public/private partnerships will allow this community to grow economically. She and Dr. McGoodwin talked about sharing information from each other's CIPs (Capital Improvements Plan) and working together to determine what capital items go forward.

Mr. Irish does not want to make cuts so deep that it affects economic development.

Mr. Koloski asked about a cooperative effort for leasing vehicles. Mayor Lovett said that is something to look into.

Mr. Koloski asked about using the Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center for adult classes in culinary arts and building trades. Dr. McGoodwin said that there may be talk of expanding utilization of the facility.

Mr. Damren said 10 years ago, Golden Cross and the Fire Department ran a successful EMT training there. He suggested that a number of industries would welcome the opportunity to offer training there.

Dr. McGoodwin said it is a goal for the fall of 2018 for students to be able to have access to those programs.

Mr. Pope suggested continuing the discussion with the person that runs the adult education program, Amy Hood. He said she's interested in growing the program.

Mr. Irish talked about the cost for lighting the sports fields (approximately \$120,000) and because the lights are used mostly by the school, he suggested putting them under the School Board to qualify for a reduction in cost. Mayor Lovett suggested Dr. McGoodwin work with the incoming City Manager on that.

Rep. Cloutier said the House's final vote on the state budget is the first Thursday in April. He suggested having the next joint meeting just before that.

Mayor Lovett said they would probably set the next meeting for the end of March.

#### **ADJOURNMENT**

**At 7:43 p.m., a motion was made by Ms. Towle and seconded by Mr. Pope to adjourn.**

**Voice vote: motion carried 7-0.**

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell  
Clerk to the Council